SEND WITH THE SCRIPT

Self-recording guide

Reality-TV confessional style: you sit and talk to the camera, deadpan. No interviewer, so prop up your own phone, or let whoever sent you this hold it, and record it in five minutes whenever you have a free moment.

Setup

- **Nobody films you.** Prop your phone horizontal against a stack of books or a mug, at face height, about an arm's length away. Sit in a chair against a plain wall or a bookshelf.
- **Light:** face a window or a lamp. Don't sit with a window behind you.
- **Eyeline:** look just to the side of the lens, as if a producer is sitting next to the phone. Glancing at the lens once or twice is fine.
- **Tone:** deadpan beats hammy. You are a sincere person who has nothing to hide and is slightly annoyed to be asked.

Recording

- **The script:** read it from a second screen or a printout taped just under the phone. The *(beat)* and *(pause)* marks are where the laughs live. Hold them longer than feels natural.
- **Takes:** two max. Send the slightly flubbed one. Don't edit anything.
- **Length:** 60 to 90 seconds. Start recording, wait two seconds, begin. Stop two seconds after the last line.
- **Send it:** text or AirDrop the raw video to whoever sent you the script. They add the title card and load it onto the classroom laptop.

Making the script yours

Words in [brackets] are adjustable. The box at the top of your script sorts them: a few **must match the case file** (your clothing color, the time, a shoe size), because the kids cross-check what you say against printed evidence; if one of those is wrong for you, tell whoever sent you this before recording and it gets changed everywhere. Your clothing color only has to be true for "yesterday": wear it on camera if you can, but the lines work if you can't. The rest is flavor. Swap in your real life, your real subject, your real habits. True details get the biggest laughs.

The ask (email or text to each suspect)

Subject: 5 minutes of acting for the 4th grade Halloween party?

Hi [Name],

Mrs. Driscoll's class Halloween party on Oct 30 is a whodunit, and the kids are going to investigate four staff "suspects." Would you be one of the three who record a statement? All it takes is a 90-second video of yourself that you can record alone on your phone whenever you have a free minute. No one films you, no one edits you, and you don't need to attend the party.

Attached is your script. It's a monologue, so just talk to the camera. Quick tips:
• Phone horizontal, propped at face height, plain wall behind you
• Look just beside the lens, like a producer is sitting there
• Deadpan. Sincere. Slightly annoyed to be asked.
• Hold the pauses. Two takes max. Send me the raw video by [Oct 23].

The kids will watch it on the projector during the party and, I promise, lose their minds. Thank you!

[Your name] · [room parent for Mrs. Driscoll's class] · [phone]

The Custodian gets a different ask: "You're a suspect who declined to comment. That's it. That's the whole job. Please act shifty in the hallway on Oct 30."

VIDEO 4 · PLAYS AFTER THE ARREST WARRANTS ARE READ

VIDEO 4 — THE CONFESSION — THE CHIEF

self-recorded monologue, ~90 sec · Starts defensive, cracks fast, ends with the location of the loot.

TITLE CARD · INTERVIEW 4 · THE CHIEF · 1:15 PM · (recorded under protest)

MAKE IT YOURS (read before you record)

- Must match the case file, because you are the one person who matches every clue: shoe size [10] (the footprint), in the building at [2:15] (the ghost words), wearing [orange] (the ransom P.S.; wear it at the party for sure, and on camera if you can), and loving squishies (the witness). If any of these should be different for you, tell the room parent before anything is printed; the footprint, the ransom note, the posters, and the case file all change together.
- Linked to other clues: "squeezed one and whispered 'so satisfying'" is Squad Nightshade's witness statement; [the avocado one] is in Squad Specter's statement and the Gym Teacher's video. Keep both.
- Must match the Principal: "[He] walked in on me" and "[he] said squishies in a MEETING once." Use the Principal's real pronoun; the slip in Video 1 only works if the Principal is the one who knew.
- Free to change: [twenty] (the real class size), [a math lesson] and [fractions] (whatever you were actually teaching), "I live here, basically."
- Keep exactly: "It IS satisfying, though," "a swamp that's learning fractions" (or your subject), and the last four lines. "A very special light" is the cue for the blacklight finale.

Words in [brackets] are yours to adjust. Say them naturally, without the brackets.

(Sit. Arms crossed. Look just beside the camera. You are offended to be here.)

I want it on the record that I am not a suspect. I'm the Chief. The Chief is never a suspect. That's how it works.

(beat)

Yes, my shoes are a size [10]. Lots of people are a size [10].

Yes, I was in the building at [2:15]. I'm a teacher. I'm always in the building. I live here, basically.

(if you're wearing it, look down at your clothes)

Yes, I was wearing [orange]. ...I wear a lot of [orange]. It's festive.

(pause)

And yes, I heard what the witness said. That the thief squeezed one and whispered "so satisfying."

(very long pause. Quietly:)

It IS satisfying, though.

(beat. Uncross your arms. Exhale.)

Fine. FINE. It was me. I took the jar. And yes, it was squishies. It was always squishies. Do you know why I labeled it "candy"? Because if I had labeled it "squishies," that jar would have lasted eleven minutes. Do you know what it's like to teach [a math lesson] while [twenty] squishies get squeezed in rhythm? It sounds like a swamp. A swamp that's learning [fractions].

So I didn't steal it. I RELOCATED it. For safekeeping. From myself, mostly.

(wince)

And yes, the Principal knew. [He] walked in on me. Mid-relocation. Arms full. I gave [him] [the avocado one] to keep quiet. Clearly that didn't work. [He's] terrible at secrets. [He] said "squishies" in a MEETING once.

(lean in, almost proud)

Where are they now? Somewhere in that room. In plain sight. Hidden the only way a teacher knows how.

(beat)

You'd need a very special light to see them.

(look right into the lens for the first time)

Nice work, detectives. Now go find them.

(beat)

And if anyone squeezes one during math on Monday, I will do it again.

(Reach toward the camera and stop recording.)

Two takes max. Send the slightly flubbed one.